believed that I should cut rates in acknowledgement of his efforts at fiscal consolidation, and would assert his arguments more firmly and forcefully.

I have been asked both while in office, and even more so after I stepped down, if there was pressure from the government to not tighten interest rates. I will write about this in a little more detail in a later chapter devoted to the autonomy and accountability of the Reserve Bank but the short answer is that there indeed was pressure.

Despite these pressures and disagreements, the meetings were always cordial; both Chidambaram and Pranab Mukherjee were invariably courteous. I know many people think that Chidambaram has an abrasive streak but I never experienced it. Even when I was his direct subordinate as finance secretary, he always treated me with courtesy and respect. Sure, he would, on occasion, show some irritation, but certainly no more irritation than I did with my own colleagues in the office. Chidambaram's behaviour towards me after I became governor was even more meticulous. For example, if there was going to be any delay in making it at the appointed time, his office would invariably call my office to let us know of that so as 'not to keep the governor waiting'.

There was some old-world charm to the way Pranab Mukherjee held both the institution of the Reserve Bank and the office of the governor in high esteem. As finance minister, he was criticized for being locked into the '70s mindset, not realizing that the world of finance had undergone a sea change in the three decades since. There were some positive dimensions to this so-called 'lock-in' though; one of them was that he looked upon the Reserve Bank with the respect that he developed for the institution in the '70s when as a younger and aspirational politician, he looked up to the stalwart governors of the Reserve Bank.

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I have already written about how, when I went to call on him after my appointment as governor, the prime minister encouraged me to see him whenever I felt the need to. In deference to this suggestion, I made a